The Keeper of Skarvøy Light

A Sample Novella

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Part One

Chapter 1: The Fog

The fog came in from the west on the first evening of October, rolling over the skerries like wet wool. Halvor Moen had kept the light on Skarvøy for eleven years, and he knew the sound the sea made when it was about to disappear. It went quiet first. Then the gulls stopped arguing, and then there was nothing at all but the slow breathing of the swell against the rocks below the tower.

He climbed the ninety-two steps with a lamp in one hand and the logbook under his arm.[1] The office at the top was cramped and smelled of paraffin, brass polish and old coffee. Mr. Moen did not mind. He had always found the small room more comfortable than the house below, where every chair still remembered his wife.

Lighthouse keepers of that era were expected to follow the printed regulations to the letter (Hansen, 1923). The regulations were clear about many things, but they said nothing about loneliness, and nothing about what a man should do when the fog lasted for nine days.[2] Halvor had read them so many times that he could recite whole pages from memory, the way his father had recited psalms.

The Logbook

Every evening followed the same order, and he wrote each step into the book before he did it:

1. Trim the wick and clean the soot from the glass.
2. Wind the clockwork that turned the great lens.

[1] The original logbooks from Skarvøy were later registered in the coastal archive.

3. Record the wind, the sea state and the visibility.

At eight o'clock the lens began to turn. Its beam swept out into the grey and was swallowed almost at once, but Halvor knew it was there, and he knew that somewhere out in the dark a skipper was counting the flashes: three short, one long, the signature of Skarvøy.

Near midnight he heard an engine. It was faint and irregular, coughing like an old man on a cold morning, and it came from the north where no boat had any business being. He stood at the gallery rail for a long time, listening, until the sound faded and the fog closed over the place where it had been.

Chapter 2: The Storm

By the third day the fog had lifted and the wind had taken its place. The barometer fell so quickly that Halvor tapped the glass twice to make sure it was not stuck. He went down to the boathouse and checked the supplies he kept for weather like this:

- two cans of lamp oil, sealed with wax
- a tin of matches wrapped in oilcloth
- a spare burner and a coil of rope

The storm arrived in the afternoon. It came as a wall of white water that broke across the outer skerry and threw spray as high as the lantern room. The whole tower hummed with it, a low note that Halvor felt in his teeth more than he heard it with his ears. Inside, the flame stood perfectly still behind its glass, indifferent to everything happening outside.

He did not sleep that night. He sat in the office with a blanket over his shoulders and wrote in the logbook every hour, as the regulations demanded, even though there was nothing new to report except that the wind was still blowing and the light was still burning. Dr. Aune, who came out with the supply boat each month, had once told him that writing things down was a way of keeping a conversation going when there was no one to talk to. Halvor had laughed at the time. He was not laughing now.

Part Two

Chapter 3: The Ship

When the storm finally blew itself out, the morning was so clear that the mountains on the mainland looked close enough to touch. Halvor walked the shoreline as he always did after bad weather, looking for damage and for whatever the sea had decided to give back. He found a broken oar, a fish crate with a Danish name stencilled on its side, and then, wedged between two boulders, the wooden nameboard of a boat.[2]

It said *Solveig* in faded green letters. He knew the name. Every keeper on the coast knew it, because the *Solveig* had been reported missing three weeks earlier with two men aboard, and the notice was still pinned to the wall of his office beside the tide tables (Berg & Lund 2001, p. 14).

He carried the board up to the tower and laid it on the table, and for a long time he simply looked at it. Then he opened the logbook to the night of the fog and read his own handwriting: *engine heard to the north, irregular, faded after midnight.* He had written it as a curiosity. Now it read like a message that had arrived too late.

Later he would learn that the coastal administration published its records online, at https://www.example.org/archive/skarvoy?year=1931, but that was many years in the future, and on that clear morning there was only the board, the book and the long silence of the island.

[2] Some accounts claim the nameboard was found by a fisherman; this detail is disputed.

Chapter 4: The Return

The supply boat came on the Thursday. Dr. Aune stepped onto the jetty with a sack of letters and a crate of tinned food, took one look at Halvor's face and asked what had happened. Halvor showed him the nameboard and the page in the logbook, and the doctor read it twice before he said anything.

"You could not have known," Dr. Aune said at last. "Nobody could have found them in that fog."

"I know," said Halvor. "But I heard them."

They took the board back to the mainland together so that it could be returned to the families. Halvor had not left the island in four years. The village looked smaller than he remembered, and louder, and the people stared at him as if he were a visitor from another century. A woman he did not recognise thanked him for bringing the board home, and he did not know what to say, so he simply nodded and held her hand for a moment.

That evening he was back on Skarvøy. He climbed the ninety-two steps, trimmed the wick, wound the clockwork and wrote the weather into the book. Then, below the weather, he added a line that was not required by any regulation: *Light lit at eight o'clock, for those who are still out there.* The lens began to turn, and its beam went out across the calm water, three short and one long, as far as it could reach.